

Some pampas grasses can grow to a height of 8 ft (2.5 m).



The lack of trees and bushes on the pampas means that many animals and birds have to take cover in underground burrows.



Today large areas of the pampas are used by farmers for raising beef cattle.

Camouflage colors

The mottled patterns on the elegant crested tinamou's feathers camouflage it on the open grasslands. It has powerful legs and can run fast for short distances, but soon becomes tired. It is not good at flying and often collides with obstacles. The bird lays bright green eggs in a hollow in the ground.



Elegant crested tinamou
(*Eudromia elegans*)
Length: up to 16 in (41 cm)

Long-legged wolf

The maned wolf has long legs, enabling it to move easily through the long pampas grass. When threatened by an enemy, the mane of hair on its neck and shoulders stands up to make it look bigger and more frightening.



Maned wolf
(*Chrysocyon brachyurus*)
Body length: up to 3 ft 9 in (1.15 m)
Tail: up to 19.7 in (50 cm)

Sharp claws

The Brazilian guinea pig is the wild ancestor of the pet guinea pig. It has sharp claws and is a good digger, but often prefers to use burrows made by other animals or to shelter under rocks. Brazilian guinea pigs usually live in small groups, but sometimes hundreds of them may live together.

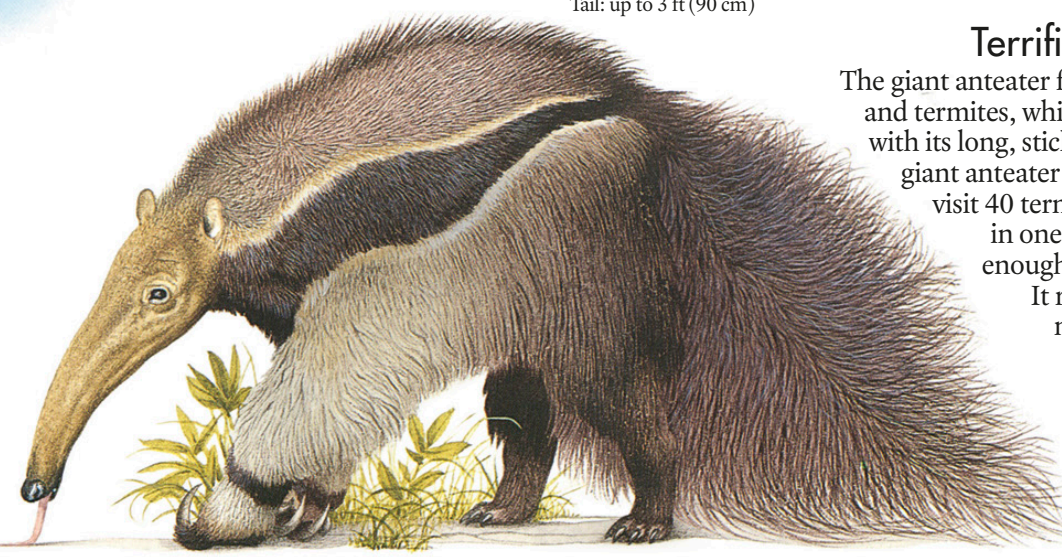


Brazilian guinea pig (*Cavia aperea*)
Body length: up to 15.5 in (39.5 cm)

Giant anteater
(*Myrmecophaga tridactyla*)
Body length: up to 4 ft 7 in (1.4 m)
Tail: up to 3 ft (90 cm)

Terrific tongue

The giant anteater feeds on ants and termites, which it licks up with its long, sticky tongue. A giant anteater may have to visit 40 termite mounds in one hour to find enough food to eat. It rips open the mounds with its claws.



Burrowing owl
(*Athene cunicularia*)
Length: up to 10 in (26 cm)

Daytime owl

Unlike most other owls, the burrowing owl hunts during the day. It perches on the mounds of soil dug out by viscachas, watching for insects or other small animals to stir in the grass. Its long legs help it run fast over the ground and catch its food. This owl nests in an underground burrow.